

Onboarding teardown

Week 2 Lecture 2 · B2C to \$10k MRR

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What we'll cover today

- **Teardown method:** how to read an onboarding like an engineer reads code
- **Sign-up friction taxonomy:** account vs guest vs deferred
- **Empty-state design:** what to show a user who has no data yet
- **Three teardowns:** Duolingo, an indie hit, your own product
- **Five experiments worth shipping this week**

How to read an onboarding

The observer's mindset

To teardown an onboarding, you need two things:

1. A fresh account you have never used before (incognito or a new email)
2. A timer

Start the timer when the landing page loads. Stop it when you first feel the product delivered its core promise.

That elapsed time is the product's TTV. Write it down.

The drop-off diagnosis framework

Amorim (PostHog, 2025) nine-step method, distilled:

1. Define what activation means for this product
2. Build a funnel from landing to activation event
3. Identify the step with the steepest drop
4. Watch session replays of users who stopped at that step
5. Form a hypothesis: friction? value gap? trust gap?
6. Ship one change with a feature flag
7. Measure

The hypothesis step is the most common skip. Don't skip it.

Sign-up friction taxonomy

Three modes: account, guest, deferred

Account-first: sign up before you see anything. Highest friction. Justified only if the product requires identity from the first action (banking, social, collaboration).

Guest mode: try the product fully before creating an account. Used by Figma, many design tools, games. Account creation is prompted after value delivery.

Deferred registration: start an action (build something, answer questions), then gate save/share on account creation. Very low friction, very high intent at the gate.

The question to ask: at what point does a user have enough invested to want to save?

Every required field before value is a drop tax

Things founders add to sign-up because they feel useful:

- Company name
- Job title
- Use case survey
- Phone number
- Payment method (before trial)

Each one has a cost in abandonment. Some are worth it. Most aren't.

Paul Graham (2013): the best early-stage onboarding is often done manually and does not scale. That is not a deficiency. It is how you discover what to automate.

Empty-state design

The blank canvas problem

A new user's first session often lands in an empty product. No data, no history, no examples. The product looks broken or useless.

Two responses:

1. **Demo data:** pre-populate with realistic sample content. User sees what the product looks like when it works. Low-friction, but can feel fake.
2. **Actionable prompt:** a single prominent call-to-action that drives the user toward their first value event. Nothing else on the screen.

The demo data trap: filling the screen with fake data the user must delete before doing real work. This adds friction, not removes it.

Empty-state copy is not decoration

Bad empty-state copy: "No items yet."

Better: "Create your first [thing] to start tracking [benefit]."

Best: a pre-filled first-item the user edits into their real thing.

The goal of the empty state is to get the user to take the one action that moves them toward the activation event. Every word either helps that or doesn't belong.

Three teardowns

Teardown: Duolingo onboarding

1. Language and goal selection: no account required, personalization creates commitment
2. First lesson starts immediately: value delivered before any gate
3. Account creation prompt after first lesson: at peak investment
4. Streak mechanic introduced in session one: the aha moment is completing a lesson, not creating an account

Lessons: defer registration, deliver value immediately, introduce the retention hook in session one.

Teardown: category leader pattern

What the best-in-class products share:

- TTV under 2 minutes
- First session ends with a concrete artifact the user created
- Account creation is prompted after that artifact exists
- Empty states use actionable prompts, not blank canvases

The activation event is designed to be reachable in the first session.
Not the second. Not after setup.

Teardown: your own product

The teardown method for your own product:

1. Open incognito. Start timer.
2. Go to your landing page. Read it as a stranger.
3. Click the primary CTA. Note every step.
4. Stop when you reach your activation event, or when you would have quit.
5. Time elapsed. Steps taken. Friction points noted.
6. Compare against your session replay data for users who didn't activate.

Where did the session replay users stop that you pushed through?

That gap is your activation experiment.

Five experiments worth shipping this week

1. **Remove one required form field** from sign-up. Any one.
2. **Rewrite empty-state copy** to name a specific next action.
3. **Pre-populate demo data** so the product looks alive on arrival.
4. **Move account creation** to after the user's first value event.
5. **Add a progress indicator** to the onboarding sequence so users know they're close.

Pick the one that addresses your biggest observed drop-off step. Ship it by Thursday. Measure Friday.

Take-aways

1. Drop-off diagnosis requires a hypothesis about the type of friction: UX, value gap, or trust gap. Without a hypothesis, you are guessing.
2. Every sign-up field that precedes value delivery is a drop tax. Audit yours.
3. Empty-state copy drives the user toward the activation event or it wastes the most valuable screen in your product.
4. Demo data helps when it shows what the product looks like in use. It hurts when the user must delete it before starting.
5. Ship one experiment this week. One. Measure it. That is enough.

"You'll be doing different things when you're acquiring users a thousand at a time... But if the market exists you can usually start by recruiting users manually and then gradually switch to less manual methods."

— Paul Graham, Do Things That Don't Scale (2013)

What's next

- **Section:** Activation audit with your partner. Bring your onboarding screenshots.
- **Friday milestone:** one activation experiment shipped; activation rate measured
- **Week 3:** Retention. What happens after they activate.
- **Assignment HW1 due:** Funnel + first instrumentation